

 Politeknik Negeri Bandung	General English 2	
	Lecturer: Muhammad Yazidus Syukri, S.S., M.Pd.	Skill focus: Reading
	Duration: 4 x 50'	Topic 2: Vocabulary in Context
Equipment:	Whiteboard, board marker, handout, LCD projector, laptop, screen	
Objectives:	After completing this lesson you will be able to: 1. Identify words that have more than one meaning 2. Recognize words that mean the same or the opposite 3. Recognize technical terms and jargon used by a special group 4. Locate and use context clues	
Student's name:		Date: February 2022

One of the most fundamental vocabulary skills is how to use context to determine the meaning. Using a dictionary is, of course, the best way to define a word. But if you're in a testing situation and you are not allowed to use one, you must rely on the context clues in the sentence.

❖ DEFINITION

context: the words and sentences that surround a word or phrase and help convey its meaning

THE WONDER OF WORDS

As you read, you have to think about what all the words and groups of words mean. And sometimes you come across a word you don't know. What does it mean? You need to figure out the meaning so you can understand what the author's trying to tell you. And you want to know what it means so you can add it to your vocabulary for future use! So what can you do? Well, you could look up the word in a dictionary. Or you could ask someone to tell you what it means. But you become a better and more active reader when you figure it out for yourself.

In this section of the book, you'll discover how you can do that by identifying words that have more than one meaning, distinguishing between words that sound alike but have different meanings, recognizing words that mean the same or the opposite, distinguishing between word parts, recognizing technical terms and jargon used by special groups, locating and using context clues, distinguishing between what a word means and what it suggests.

Ever since you learned your first English words, you have been determining meaning from context. **Context** refers to the words and sentences that surround a particular word and help convey its meaning.

You can use the context of a sentence—or **context clues**—to help you detect the meaning of a word. Simply put, this means that you can look for clues in and around the vocabulary word. The term *context clues* mean that other words in the sentence “give away” or “give clues” to the definition. For example, sometimes you'll find **synonyms** (words that mean the same thing) or **antonyms** (words that mean the opposite), or details that lead you to identify the vocabulary word in question. Once in a while, you'll find a group of words set off by commas (called an **appositive**), which gives you a very clear definition of the word.

WORD-OF-THE-DAY WEBSITES

Dictionary.com Word of the Day

www.dictionaryreference.com

Sample words: altruistic, churlish, glower, bonanza

Merriam-Webster Word of the Day

<http://www.merriam-webster.com/word-of-the-day/>

Sample words: diligent, genuflect, sustain, QWERTY

WordThink.com

www.wordthink.com

Sample words: incongruous, assiduous, anecdotal, pragmatic

Merriam-Webster's Learner's Dictionary (for ESL English-language learners)

www.learnersdictionary.com

Sample words: gamble, reserve, crucial, secure

Five Techniques for Acquiring Words

This section introduces some techniques to help you learn new words and retain them better.

TECHNIQUES FOR ACQUIRING WORDS

- Use the Three-Dot Method
- Use Vocabulary Note Cards
- Break New Words Down into Their Component Parts
- Develop an Interest in Etymology
- Subscribe to a Word-of-the-Day Website

po.ten.tial (p e-'ten(t)-sh el) adj. **1.** Capable of being but not yet in existence; latent: a potential problem. **2.** Having possibility, capability, or power. **3.** Grammar Of, relating to, or being a verbal construction with auxiliaries such as may or can; for example, it may snow. n. **1.** The inherent ability or capacity for growth, development, or coming into being. **2.** Something possessing the capacity for growth or development. **3.** Grammar: A potential verb form. . . .

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COMMON TYPES OF NONFICTION

- ✓ Books on history, politics, social problems, and so on
- ✓ Editorials or opinion pieces
- ✓ Material on websites (information sites, blogs, and the like)
- ✓ Essays
- ✓ Memoirs and journals
- ✓ Textbooks
- ✓ Practical reading material like credit card inserts, contracts, nutritional information on processed food items, and recipes

USE IT OR LOSE IT

There's really only one rule for building your vocabulary: *Use it or lose it*. When you are learning a new word, if you don't use it, you will soon forget what it means. Write new words down on a vocabulary list. Use them in e-mails or letters to friends. Introduce them to members of your family. Use the words you learn in your everyday communications as much as possible so they become a permanent part of your vocabulary.

Now, notice how the context of the sentence below helps give the word *candor* its meaning:

➡ I admire Arun's candor, but sometimes, he can be a bit *too* honest.

Candor means

- a. irritability.
- ☒ b. frank, sincere speech.
- c. readiness to judge or criticize others.
- d. comfort with speaking in front of people.

Based on the context of the sentence, only **b** can be the correct answer. The speaker tells you that Arun is sometimes *too* honest, thus signifying that *candor* means frank, sincere speech—Arun tells people exactly what he thinks. Even if you can't figure out exactly what *candor* means, you can tell from the context

whether it is something positive or negative, and this can help you narrow down your answer choices on an exam. In this case, because the speaker admires Arun's candor, you can assume that candor is a positive thing. You can therefore eliminate choices **a** and **c**.

There are four types of context clues that can help you:

1. Restatement
2. Positive/Negative
3. Contrast

4. Specific Detail

This sentence uses two types of context clues: restatement and positive/negative. The first part of the sentence tells you that candor is a good thing (positive/negative), while the second part essentially restates the meaning of the word. Here's another example of a sentence that uses these two types of context clues:

➡ Hani suddenly found himself *destitute*, so poor that he could barely afford to eat.

The context clearly reveals that *destitute* is not a positive word; it is not a good thing to be so poor one can barely afford to eat. The context also restates the meaning of *destitute*, essentially defining the word within the sentence, so that you can tell exactly what *destitute* means—extremely poor.

There are two other types of context clues to watch for. Read the following paragraph as an example (but *don't* look up the italicized words!):

Sarah had worked so hard for the past few weeks that she decided she owed herself a day of complete *indolence*. Saturday, she slept until noon, ordered take-out so she wouldn't have to cook, and left the dishes in the sink. She left her chores for another day and spent the afternoon lying on the couch, reading and watching television. But on Sunday, she was back to her old *assiduous* self, and by noon, she had already cleaned her whole apartment, done her grocery shopping, and paid her bills. How do you know what *indolence* means? From two more types of context clues: contrast and specific detail. The first sentence suggests that *indolence* is in contrast to working hard, while the second and third sentences confirm this with specific details. Thus you can determine what *indolence* means. Let's say you were given the choices below:

- a. luxurious
- b. hard labor
- c. deep sleep
- d. laziness

The correct answer is **d**, laziness. The specific details tell you that Sarah did her best to laze around the house all day. Besides, you know the other answers are incorrect because Sarah didn't do anything luxurious (choice **a**) and she didn't do any work or chores (choice **b**). There's no mention of sleep in the paragraph, so choice **c** is also incorrect.

Now let's look at the context in which *assiduous* is used. Again, you have two kinds of context clues: contrast and specific detail. You know that the *assiduous* Sarah of Sunday was very different from the *indolent* Sarah of Saturday (contrast). You also know what the *assiduous* Sarah does: She is very, very busy on Sunday, cleaning and working around the house (specific detail). *Assiduous* means diligent, hardworking;

or persevering, unrelenting.

DENOTATION AND CONNOTATION

The **denotation** of a word is simply its dictionary definition. For instance, look at the dictionary definitions of the following words.

- ➡ procrastination: to postpone or delay needlessly
- ➡ lazy: to be resistant to work or exertion; slow moving or sluggish
- ➡ inactive: not active or not tending to be active; not functioning or operating

Some English words, however, have more than one meaning. A *quack*, for example, is the sound a duck makes, but a *quack* is also an untrained or unqualified person who pretends to be a doctor.

Words also have another meaning beyond their denotation. Each word also has a **connotation**—an implied meaning or emotional impact. Sometimes, the connotation can be favorable or positive. Other times the connotation can be unfavorable or negative. Then again, some words do not arouse any emotion at all and have a neutral connotation.

For example, if you were to look up the word *playful* in the dictionary, you might get a definition similar to that of two of its synonyms, *spirited* and *mischievous*. But all three of these words have different connotations and bring to mind different feelings. *Spirited* has a positive connotation and *mischievous* a negative connotation, while *playful* is neutral in tone.

DEFINITIONS

denotation: a word's exact meaning or dictionary definition

connotation: a word's implied meaning or emotional impact

When you come across an unfamiliar word, the context will often reveal a great deal about the connotation of that word, even if it does not provide enough information for you to determine its denotation. At a minimum, the connotations of the surrounding words will usually tell you whether the vocabulary word is positive or negative. Therefore, when you are looking for context clues, make sure you look at the surrounding words carefully and consider their denotations and connotations.

HERE'S A HINT

ALL SYNONYMS ARE NOT CREATED EQUAL

Synonyms are words that share the same meaning or nearly the same meaning as other words. It is important to know that there are often many synonyms for one word. While some synonyms can be similar, they are rarely identical. For instance, the words *bountiful*, *ample*, *plentiful*, and *glut* suggest abundance. However, one of these words suggests an overabundance. While you can have a bountiful, ample, or plentiful supply of food on the table for a dinner party, a glut of food is an excessive amount of food that suggests there will be waste involved. It is important to choose your words carefully and to be as clear as possible when choosing synonyms.

Although some synonyms are interchangeable, most words have their own unique connotation. So while test questions will often ask you to identify synonyms such as *laconic*, *terse*, and *succinct*, when it comes to your own communications, you should choose your words carefully. *Terse*, for example, has the most positive connotation of these three words, suggesting brevity with a sense of polish or elegance. *Succinct* is more neutral, conveying a sense of compactness or tightness in how an idea has been expressed. *Laconic*, on the other hand, conveys the same basic idea but with the suggestion of brusqueness or abruptness. Thus, although these words are effectively synonymous, each word carries its own specific connotation and leaves a slightly different impression.

HOW MUCH CONTEXT DO YOU NEED?

In the passage about Sarah, you would still be able to understand the main idea of the passage even if you did not know—or could not figure out—the meanings of *indolence* and *assiduous*. In some cases, though, your understanding of a sentence or paragraph depends on your understanding of a particular word or phrase. For example, you can't understand what *inept* means from the following example sentence—it simply does not provide sufficient context. In fact, you can't even figure out if it is something positive or negative, because the sentence provides almost no context at all:

➡ Sabina is an utterly *inept* dancer.

Is Sabina a *graceful* dancer? An *awkward* dancer? Or an *accomplished* dancer? You simply cannot tell from the context. But you *could* figure out what *inept* means by breaking down the word into its prefix (*in-*) and word root (*ept*). That's the subject of Chapters 2 and 3. Meanwhile, however, here's a sentence that does give you the context you need to determine the meaning of the word:

➡ Despite years of lessons, Sabina remains an utterly *inept* dancer who simply stumbles across the dance floor. Now we can tell through context that *inept* means *awkward* or *clumsy*. Being able to determine the meaning of unfamiliar words from their context is an essential vocabulary skill. Sometimes you will find unfamiliar words whose meanings are indecipherable without a dictionary. More often than not, though, a careful look at the context will give you enough clues to interpret the definition. By looking for the way the words are used in the paragraph, you can figure out what these words mean. Even if you have no idea what a word means, you can still tell something about the word by how it is used—by examining the words and ideas surrounding it. Like detectives looking for clues at a crime scene, you must look at the passage for clues that will uncover the definition of the word.

SENTENCE DETECTIVE

Deciphering some sentences can seem like an impossible mission, but like everything else worth doing, it's hard at first and gets easier as you practice. There are some basic skills you need to acquire, though. Think of yourself as a detective trying to decode a secret message. Once you have the key to the code, it's easy to decipher the message. The following sections will give you the keys you need to unlock the meanings of even the most complex sentences. The great thing is that these are master keys that can unlock any and all sentences, including the many complex sentences you will encounter in your college reading.

► Sentence Structure

The single most important key to the meaning of a sentence is its structure. The best and easiest way to determine sentence structure is to look at its punctuation. Sentence completion questions always have one or more commas or semicolons. The basic strategy is to separate the sentence into units divided by punctuation.

Often, one of the units will express a complete thought, then at least one unit will have one or two blanks. The unit that expresses a complete thought will tell you what the unit(s) with blank(s) need to say. For example, consider this sample question:

Select the word that best fills in the blank.

➡ After finding sacred objects inside numerous Mayan caves, archaeologists have begun to revise their opinion that the Maya used the caves solely for _____ functions.

- a. reverent
- b. theological
- c. religious
- d. secular

When you divide this sentence into punctuation-defined units, you have:

After finding sacred objects inside numerous Mayan caves, and archaeologists have begun to revise their opinion that the Maya used the caves solely for _____ functions.

The first unit, the unit without the blank, tells you that the second unit has something to do with what happened 1) *after* finding sacred objects and 2) in Mayan caves. The second unit, the one with the blank, tells you that 1) archaeologists have begun to revise their opinion and 2) their opinion (before being revised) was that Mayan caves were used only (*solely*) for some kind of function. Your mission is to figure out what goes in the blank, namely what kind of function archaeologists used to think the caves were exclusively used for. Now you're ready to use the first unit to illuminate the second. If scientists used to think *one thing* until they found *sacred objects*, it means they used to think the caves were *not* used for sacred purposes. Now you know you need to fill in the blank with a word that means "not sacred," a word such as *civic*, or *secular*. Your final step is to look at the answer choices to find the one that matches the idea you have formed about what needs to be in the blank(s). Choice **d**, *secular*, is the best answer choice. Here's an example of a sample question that doesn't divide neatly into a complete unit and an incomplete unit. This question has a blank in each of its two units.

Select the words that best fill in the blanks:

➡ The famous daredevil was actually quite _____ by temperament, as illustrated by the fact that he did not _____ until he was two years old.

- a. reckless . . . amble
- b. careful . . . perambulate
- c. adventurous . . . rest
- d. daring . . . scuttle

The first unit is *The famous daredevil was actually quite _____ by temperament*. The word *actually* tells us that there is something unexpected going on. If *actually* were to be removed from the sentence, there'd be no way you could know what kind of words go in the blanks. *Actually* is a clue word, one that points you toward the meaning of the sentence. The *famous daredevil actually* had an unexpected kind of temperament. What kind of temperament would you expect a famous daredevil to have? Adventurous, bold, daring, right? So the word that goes in the first blank will be one that has a contrasting relationship to that expected temperament.

The second unit of the sentence, *as illustrated by the fact that he did not _____ until he was two years old*, uses a phrase of comparison, *as illustrated by*, to let us know that the word that goes in the blank should complete the idea of the daredevil's having a temperament that is not bold. Think of a synonym for "not bold." Put it in the first blank. Now read the sentence using your word in the first blank. Think of something

that, if not done before age two, would indicate that kind of temperament. The next thing you do is look at the answer choices for words that are similar to the ones you chose. The best answer to this question is choice **b**, *careful . . . perambulate*. Even if you didn't know that to *perambulate* is to walk, or move about on one's own, you could be fairly confident that you had the right answer because *careful* is such a good choice.

► A Clue for You

The second important skill you must master for sentence completion questions is the ability to identify key words and phrases. These are the words that most help you decode the sentence. Think of them as clues to a mystery. Among the most useful of these are the words that enable you to identify the logical relationship between the complete unit(s) of the sentence and the incomplete unit(s). As in the preceding example, sometimes you have to complete one portion of a two-blank sentence before you can work on the logical relationship of another unit. There are three types of logical relationships commonly expressed in sentence completion questions: contrast, comparison, and cause and effect. Mastering these three relationships will help you succeed on sentence completion questions.

CONTRAST

Some words that logically signal a relationship of contrast are: *though, although, however, despite, but, and yet*. Can you think of others? There are also phrases that signal a contrast between the units of the sentence, such as *on the other hand, but, however, despite, or on the contrary*.

Try making a sentence using these words and phrases. See how the two parts of your sentence oppose each other. This is the logical relationship of contrast, or opposition. No matter how complex a sentence completion question seems at first glance, when you see one of these words or phrases, you will know you're looking at a sentence that expresses one thought in its complete unit and a contrasting thought in the incomplete unit. First you decipher the thought in the complete unit, then fill in the blank in the incomplete unit with a word that expresses a contrasting thought. For example:

➡ Although the tiger is primarily a solitary beast, its cousin the lion is a _____ animal.

First divide the sentence into two units, using the punctuation to guide you. Now you have as the first unit, *Although the tiger is primarily a solitary beast*, and, *its cousin the lion is a _____ animal*, as the second unit. The first unit tells you by the use of the word *although* that the second unit will express a relationship of opposition or contrast. You can see that tigers and lions are being contrasted. The word that goes in the blank has to be an adjective that describes *animal* in the way that *solitary* describes *beast*. Therefore the word that will contrast with the idea in the first unit is in opposition to *solitary*. What is an antonym of *solitary*? *Solitary* means alone. You might choose the word *social*. *Friendly, gregarious, or sociable* are other options, all meaning "not solitary." Then you look for the word in the answer choices that is a synonym of the word you chose.

COMPARISON

There are two kinds of comparison relationships: comparison by similarity and comparison by restatement. Words that signal comparison include *likewise, similarly, and and*. Phrases that introduce comparisons are *just as, as well as, for example, as shown, and as illustrated by*. Words and phrases that precede restatement are *namely, in other words, in fact, and that is*. Relationships of logical comparison are straightforward.

The idea expressed in the complete unit of the sentence is similar to or the same as the idea that needs to be expressed in the incomplete unit. When you know what the complete unit says, you know what the incomplete unit needs to say—the same thing, or very nearly so. Here's an example of a comparison sentence:

➡ Until he went to military school, Foster never stood up straight; as illustrated by his _____ in this photograph.

This sentence has three units, two complete and one incomplete. The first two units tell you that before military school, Foster slouched. The blank in the third unit, therefore, needs to be filled by a word that will illustrate his slouching. The correct answer will be *posture*, or its synonym.

ON YOUR OWN

PRACTICE REALLY LISTENING

Some of the best resources for nonnative English speakers trying to increase their vocabularies are CDs or audiotapes. English is a difficult language because it is so visually confusing. One of the ways you most often encounter vocabulary is by listening. Vocabulary CDs and tapes are available in libraries and bookstores. You may also find it helpful to use a nonfiction or fiction book and the same

book in audio form (CD or audiotape). Play the audio version of the book as you read along in the book. This will help you match the word to its written form.

CAUSE AND EFFECT

A third kind of logical relationship often expressed in sentence completion questions is the cause and effect relationship. In other words, the sentence states that one thing is a result of something else. Again, you can rely on key words to point you in the right direction. Words such as *thus*, *therefore*, *consequently*, and *because*, and phrases such as *due to*, *as a result*, and *leads to* signal a cause and effect relationship.

Try making some cause and effect sentences to see how they work. Here's an example of a cause and effect sample question. Select the word that best fills in the blank.

➡ Scientific knowledge is usually _____, often resulting from years of hard work by numerous investigators.

- a. cumulative
- b. illogical
- c. decreasing
- d. irrelevant

The complete unit of the sentence, *often resulting from years of hard work by numerous investigators*, tells you that the other unit results from *numerous investigators working hard for years*. The incomplete unit, the one with the blank, tells you that you are looking for a word to describe *scientific knowledge* as a result of those years of hard work. You know that whatever word the test makers are looking for, it must have something to do with *lots of stuff*, because years of hard work by numerous investigators would produce a lot of something. The best answer choice for this question is choice a, *cumulative*, which, of course, applies to *lots of stuff*.

HERE'S A HINT

MIX AND MATCH SENTENCES

To help you remember some important verbs and adjectives, match verbs and adjectives together in pairs that will help you recall their meaning. Here are several examples:

- You *abhor* what is *odious*.
- You might *disdain* something that is *banal*.
- You won't be *daunted* if you are *intrepid*; you will be *daunted* if you are *timid*.
- You might *tout* something about which you are *fervent*.
- You might *vacillate* if you are *timid* or *diffident*.
- You might *grovel* if you are *servile*.

You can also mix and match words to create synonym and antonym pairs. *Abate* and *ebb*, for example, have nearly the same meaning, while *disdain* and *revere* are opposites.

Once you learn how to identify the complete and incomplete units of a sentence using punctuation to guide you, you've made a good start. Next you determine the logical relationship of the units, using key words and phrases; and then you understand what the sentence is saying, even if there's some vocabulary you don't understand. But if you keep working on building your vocabulary, chances are you will understand the crucial words.

ACTIVE READING

As you might expect, vocabulary in context questions ask you to determine the meanings of particular words. To prepare for these types of questions on the TOEFL iBT, it is a good idea to become an active reader. This is a skill you can practice every day. As you read an English-language newspaper or magazine, have a dictionary handy. Look up as many unfamiliar words as you can so that your bank of vocabulary words becomes as large as possible. This may sound like a contradiction, but if you make a habit of taking the time to read carefully and actively, you will actually spend *less* time learning the meaning of new vocabulary words. By reading carefully, you will often be able to determine meaning from context. By reading actively, you will continually expand your bank of vocabulary words—and the bigger your word base, the more you will comprehend, and the less time you will spend looking up words.

TIPS AND STRATEGIES

Vocabulary-in-context questions are common on standardized tests, like the TOEFL iBT. Here are some specific tips and strategies to use while preparing for and taking the exam:

- On any vocabulary-in-context question on an exam, there *will* be some kind of context clue to help you determine meaning. Remember the four types: restatement, positive/negative, contrast, and specific detail.
- Remember that you have a very powerful tool on a multiple-choice exam: the process of elimination. From the start, you can usually eliminate one or two answers that you know are incorrect. For example, you can eliminate negative choices if the context suggests the word is positive.
- To help you eliminate answers, read the sentence with each answer choice substituted for the vocabulary word. Often, putting the word in the context of the sentence can help you determine whether an answer is right or wrong.
- Consider the tone and connotation of the other words in the sentence. At a minimum, this can often help you determine whether the vocabulary word is positive or negative.
- Look for introductory words and phrases such as *unfortunately*, *however*, *surprisingly*. These words often tell you whether the word is positive or negative and/or set up contrast clues.
- Read carefully. Look for specific details that provide clues to meaning.
- If you have heard the vocabulary word before but aren't sure what it means, try to remember the context in which you heard it used before. This may help you better use the context as it is presented on the exam.

PRACTICE QUESTIONS

Choose the best vocabulary word to fill the blank. Circle your choices or write your answers on a separate piece of paper. Then compare your selections to the correct answers at the end of the chapter.

1. The _____ president differs from the past president on healthcare reform issues.
a. talkative ~~b. accomplished~~ c. artificial ~~d. incumbent~~
2. The _____ data supports the belief that there has been an increase in population in the county.
~~a. nominal~~ ~~b. demographic~~ c. practical d. nocturnal
3. The _____ collected from real estate taxes helped to balance the town budget.
a. domain b. remainder ~~c. revenue~~ d. assessment
4. She pretended to be _____ about the new job opportunity, but secretly she was very excited.
a. dedicated b. receptive ~~c. candid~~ ~~d. Blasé~~
5. We were tired when we reached the _____, but the spectacular view of the valley below was worth the hike.
a. circumference ~~b. summit~~ c. fulcrum d. nadir
6. The suit had a(n) _____ odor, as if it had been stored in a trunk for a long time.
a. aged b. scented ~~c. musty~~ d. Decrepit
7. Because his workplace was so busy and noisy, he longed most of all for _____.
a. solitude b. association ~~c. loneliness~~ d. Irrelevancy
8. The teacher put the crayons on the bottom shelf to make them _____ to the young children.
~~a. accessible~~ b. receptive c. eloquent d. Ambiguous
9. My computer was state-of-the-art when I bought it three years ago, but now it is _____.
a. current b. dedicated c. unnecessary ~~d. Outmoded~~
10. Visiting all the tea shops in the city, they were on a _____ to find the perfect cup of tea.
a. surge ~~b. quest~~ c. discovery d. Cadence

11. Make sure the directions are very *explicit* so that no one makes a mistake. *Explicit* means
 a. intricate, complex. c. chronologically ordered
~~b. clearly and fully stated~~ d. ambiguous or implied.
12. The hotel is *teeming* with security personnel because the leaders of several countries are here for a summit meeting. *Teem* means
 a. to close down temporarily. c. to be full of, nearly overflowing
 b. to lose business due to circumstances beyond one's control. ~~d. to be under close scrutiny.~~
13. Karen was relieved to learn that the chemicals in her well water were all *benign*. *Benign* means
 a. natural. b. dangerous. c. of local origin. ~~d. harmless.~~
14. Although it was *futile* because he didn't meet half of the requirements, Jensen applied for the job anyway because it was his dream position. *Futile* means....
~~a. useless.~~ b. fruitful. c. radical. d. insane.
15. The editor, preferring a more *terse* writing style, cut 500 words from the 2,000-word article. *Terse* means...
 a. elegant. b. factual. c. descriptive. ~~d. concise.~~
16. Victor Frankenstein spent the last years of his life chasing his *elusive* monster, who was always one step of his creator. *Elusive* means....
 a. difficult to compare. ~~b. difficult to capture.~~ c. difficult to forget. d. difficult to avoid.
17. Xiu's timely joke served to *diffuse* the tension in the room, and the rest of the meeting was highly productive. *Diffuse* means ...
 a. to refuse. b. to intensify. c. to create. ~~d. to soften.~~
18. I completely lost track of Tula's point because she kept *digressing* to unrelated topics. *Digress* means....
~~a. to deviate, stray.~~ b. to regress, revert. c. to change the tone. d. to express concisely.
19. The senator *evaded* the question by changing the subject and accusing his opponent of misconduct. *Evade* means ...
~~a. to escape or elude.~~ b. to answer indirectly. c. to refuse to answer directly. d. to deceive.
20. Samantha hasn't said why she's been so withdrawn lately, but I would *surmise* that it is because she is still upset about not being able to go to camp. *Surmise* means
 a. to confirm. b. to surprise. c. to believe. ~~d. to guess.~~
21. Their conversation was considered playful _____ between two old friends.
 a. antics ~~b. banter~~ c. behavior d. Activities
22. He tried to _____ the sinking morale of his friend in the hospital.
~~a. sustain~~ b. foster ~~c. bolster~~ d. Nourish

PRACTICE 1: A DAY AT THE PARK

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

(1) It's a lazy Saturday. I'm happy just hanging out . . . doing nothing. Then my little brother runs into my room and announces, "We're going to the park!"

- (2) "Have fun," I reply.
- (3) "No! Get up and get ready!" he whines, and pulls my arm. "Dad said we're going to make a day of it . . . the whole family!"
- (4) Dad drops us off by the park entrance and goes to park the car. I help Mom unload the picnic basket onto a table. She's packed a huge covered plate of sandwiches, a bowl of fruit, bags of chips, lots of cookies, and a gigantic pitcher of iced tea. Mom always makes extra "just in case . . .," whatever that means!
- (5) "Before we eat, will you help me fly my new kite?" pleads my brother. With a sigh, I take his hand and lead him to a good spot for flying kites. Soon the kite's airborne and looping through the sky! Suddenly, it's harder to spot because it floats behind a tree.
- (6) "Is it lost forever?" asks my brother.
- (7) "No, just hiding. There . . . see . . . it's back!" I chuckle as the kite pops back into view.
- (8) "Dude!" I hear someone behind me say. "Just the guy I was looking for!" I turn to find Chris, one of my best friends.
- (9) "I thought you went to visit your uncle this weekend!" I say.
- (10) "No, he had to go away on business, so I'll catch him another time," Chris replies. "Nice kite," he adds, "but I was hoping to play ball today."
- (11) "I'm in," I answer. "We're about to stop. My brother wants Dad to push him on a swing."
- (12) So we find more friends to play ball. Suddenly, it's the last inning, the game is tied, and I'm at bat. I see Mom waving me to come for lunch, so there's nothing to do but hit a homer! I swing, hear the *crack* of the bat, and head for home plate. Then I invite the other kids to join us for lunch . . . knowing Mom had made extra! I guess this was the "just in case!"

- What is the meaning of the word *park* as used in the first paragraph?
 - leave a car in a parking lot
 - sit down
 - an open, public area of land used for recreation
 - an arctic jacket
- Which is NOT a meaning of *plate* as used in the story?
 - tray
 - dish
 - marker for a base
 - coat with metal
- Which of the following words from paragraph 5 is a multiple-meaning word?
 - pleads
 - spot
 - kite
 - Before
- The meaning of *back* as used in paragraph 7 is....
 - "a piece connected to the seat of a chair."
 - "the opposite of *front*."
 - "to return."
 - "to sponsor or give money to."
- The last paragraph contains all these multiple-meaning words: *play*, *ball*, *pitcher*, *tied*, *bat*, *swing*, and *head*. Choose three of the words and write short sentences illustrating at least two meanings for each.

We played football, we lost, but we gave a good play though.

I hit the bat in the cave with a bat.

The head of the school is heading towards a museum

PRACTICE 2: CROSSING OVER

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

- (1) Have you ever thought about how important a bridge is? After all, without bridges, how would people get across rivers and wide gorges? Bridges are an essential part of our transportation system for moving people and goods.
- (2) The first bridges were simply trees that fell or were placed across water or canyons. The wood was strong enough to bear the weight of a person or two at a time, but not for carrying heavy loads. People made bridges by stretching rope cables across an open area. In China and other places, rope bridges are still used. They're strong enough to hold people and pack animals with light loads.

(3) Later, people built arch bridges by wedging together large blocks of stone to form a half circle. Arch bridges are among the strongest and longest-lasting: Some built more than 1,500 years ago are still being used. Even today, people build arch bridges, but usually from concrete, wood, or steel.

(4) Another kind of bridge is the cantilever. It has two independent steel or concrete beams, one extending toward the center of a river from each bank. A third beam is lifted up to connect the beams. Canada's Quebec Bridge is one of the world's longest, spanning 1,800 feet (549 m) across the St. Lawrence River.

(5) A suspension bridge spans even more space with its roadway hanging from steel cables supported by massive towers. Each cable can hold thousands of pounds of weight. Probably the most familiar suspension bridge is California's Golden Gate, with a main span of 4,200 feet (1,280 m). When completed in 1937, it was the world's longest, but in 1964, New York's Verrazano-Narrows Bridge beat that with a span of 4,260 feet (1,298 m). Then in 1981, England's Humber Bridge beat that with a span of 4,626 feet (1,410 m). And since 1998, Japan's Akashi-Kaikyo Bridge has held the record, with a span of 1,991 feet (6,529 m). Will that record be beaten? Stay tuned!

6. What is the meaning of the word *bridge* as used in the article?

- a. the upper bony part of the nose
- b. the part of a ship where the captain works
- c. a card game
- d. pathway structure over a river or valley

7. Which is NOT a meaning of *bear* as used in the story?

- a. hold
- b. carry
- c. furry mammal
- d. support

8. What is the meaning of the word *beam* as used in the article?

- a. long piece of heavy wood or metal used in construction
- b. width of a ship at its widest part
- c. ray of light
- d. Smile

9. Which of the following words from the last paragraph is a multiple-meaning word?

- a. familiar
- b. record
- c. steel
- d. Since

10. The meaning of *still* as used in the article is....

- a. "quiet."
- b. "unmoving."
- c. "calm."
- d. "even now."

11. What is the meaning of the word *light* as used in the second paragraph?

- a. beam
- b. bright
- c. not heavy
- d. Pale

PRACTICE 3: MAKING THINGS MOVE

Read this selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

(1) Did you know that whatever you do, forces are at work on you? That's *right*. Forces keep your feet on the ground when you stand. Forces keep you sitting on a chair without slipping off. And a force guarantees that if you jump up, you're going to come down! Without forces you couldn't hold a *pen* to write, no matter whether you use your *right* or left! In the world of forces, things spin, stretch, twist, and *fly*, but only if something or someone applies a push or pull!

(2) Here on Earth, gravity pulls anything at or near the surface toward the center of the planet. Things have weight because of gravity's pull. The greater the pull, the more an object weighs. We use *scales* to measure weight. When you *step* on a scale, the numbers tell how much force Earth's gravity is pulling between you and the planet itself.

12. What is the meaning of the word *pen* as used in the first paragraph?

- a. cage
- b. writing tool
- c. scribble
- d. corral

13. Which is NOT a meaning of the word *step*?

- a. stair
- b. stage or point of directions
- c. stride
- d. high

14. Which is the meaning of *scales* as used in the passage?

- a. hard pieces that cover an animal's body
- b. climbs a steep, rocky hill

- ~~c. machines for weighing things~~
- d. draws in relative proportion

Words that sound or look alike

In this lesson, you'll discover that some words are *pronounced* the same but spelled differently and have different meanings, and some words are *spelled* the same but pronounced differently and have different meanings.

IN LESSON 1, you identified homonyms that sounded and were spelled alike, but had different meanings. In this lesson, you'll find **homophones** ("same sound") and **homographs** ("same writing"). Homophones *sound* the same but are spelled differently and have different meanings. As you read, don't let the homophones confuse you.

Examples

sees, seas, seize
for, four, fore
through, threw
toe, tow

Homographs are *spelled* the same but are pronounced differently and have different meanings. As you read, you need to figure out which pronunciation and meaning is used. The rest of the sentence usually lets you know.

Examples

The *wind* is blowing! *Wind* the balloon string around your finger. In the apartment where I *live*, they don't allow *live* animals. *Separate* your laundry. Put dark and light clothes in *separate* piles.

PRACTICE 1: A LONG JOURNEY

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

(1) Dull Knife, a leader of the Cheyenne, was born *in* Montana. His *real* name was Morning Star. He got his nickname when his knife failed to *break through* his enemy's tough, buffalo-hide armor.

(2) *In* 1876, the Cheyenne helped defeat General Custer and his U.S. troops. Other soldiers pursued the Cheyenne, and a year later, the Native Americans surrendered. They were *sent* to a reservation in Oklahoma, *where* the army promised *there* was a *herd* of buffalo *for* hunting. *There* wasn't, and many Cheyenne *died* of starvation.

(3) Dull Knife asked permission *to* take his people home. *But* the army took over a year to "think it over," and more Cheyenne *died*. Dull Knife *knew* he had to *rebel*. So the *rebel* leader and 300 of his people escaped from the reservation and headed *for* Montana, 1,000 miles away. When they crossed into Nebraska, soldiers *there* ordered Dull Knife and his people to return *to* the Oklahoma reservation. Dull Knife refused. "*I* will never go back," he said. "*You* may kill me *here*, but *you* cannot make me go back!"

(4) The soldiers wondered why Dull Knife *would* *resent* being *resent*, or *sent back to* Oklahoma. They tried *to* force him *to* agree *to* go. They *threw him* and his people *into* a freezing building with *no* food or water *for* three days. *But* the Cheyenne *would not* give up. Instead, they climbed out windows and escaped!

(5) The soldiers chased the Cheyenne. *Some* were killed or captured, *but some* escaped, including Dull Knife and his family. They walked *for* 18 days, with only tree bark and their own moccasins *to* eat! At last, they reached Montana, where sympathetic settlers had *heard* what the Cheyenne did to survive. The people asked the government *to* set up a *new* Cheyenne reservation *in* Montana. Many Cheyenne still *live there* today.

1. What does *resent* mean the first time it's used in the fourth paragraph?

- a. sent again
- b. like
- c. admit
- ~~d. be displeased about~~

2. Which homonym set was NOT used in the article?

~~a. knew and new~~

~~b. threw and through~~

~~c. died and dyed~~

~~d. herd and heard~~

3. What's the meaning of the homophone *real* as used in the article?

~~a. actual~~

b. rotation

c. spindle

d. roll

4. A homophone for *break* means

a. crack.

~~b. reduce speed.~~

c. smash.

d. accelerate.

5. Which of these words has a homograph that means "total"?

a. live

~~b. buffalo~~

c. some

~~d. bark~~

6. What does the homophone *sent* mean as used in the selection?

a. moved

~~b. one penny~~

c. smell

d. trace

PRACTICE 2: THE LAND DOWN UNDER

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

(1) Where do baby kangaroos come from? Australia, of course! That's *where* you'll find animal species not native to any other part of the world, like the koala, platypus, and kangaroo.

(2) Scientists say that about 600 million years ago, what we now *know* as Antarctica, South America, Africa, India, and Australia formed *one* huge continent called Gondwanaland. It was populated with dinosaurs and the first mammals—monotremes and marsupials. Monotremes, like the platypus, *lay* eggs from *which* *their* offspring hatch. Marsupials, like the kangaroo, *produce* offspring that develop *in* a pouch outside *their* mothers' bodies.

(3) Kangaroos are the largest marsupials. Males are called boomers, females *does*, and all babies are called joeys. What *does* the average kangaroo look like? Most adults are about 6 feet (1.8 m) tall and *weigh* about 100 pounds (45 kg). They have large hind feet, strong hind legs, and a *tail* measuring 3 feet (.9 m) or longer. A kangaroo uses its heavy tail for balance and *to* prop itself up when sitting or fighting, when it kicks the enemy with both hind feet! Normally kangaroos are quadrupeds—they use all *four* feet to walk. Even *their* short front limbs, like arms, help them move. *But* the animals stand on *two* feet when they want *to* move quickly. They can hop up to 40 miles (64 km) per *hour* over short distances and leap over 30 feet (9.2 m) *in* a single bound!

(4) About 130 million years ago, Gondwanaland broke apart and Australia was cut off from the rest of the world. Marsupials and monotremes still flourished *there*. *But* elsewhere, newer species of mammals appeared that gave birth to fully developed young. That's why you won't find kangaroos hopping across *present* day Antarctica!

7. As used in the article, which is the best meaning of the homograph *produce*?

a. harvest

~~b. bring into being~~

c. give off

d. foodstuffs

8. What is the meaning of the homophone *but* as used in the article?

a. knock against

b. strike

c. end

~~d. however~~

9. Which is a homophone for the underlined word in the third sentence?

a. gnat

b. knot

~~c. grow~~

d. know

10. Which of these words has a homograph that means "gift"?

a. single

b. balance

~~c. present~~

d. bound

11. Which homonym set was used in the article?

a. way and weigh

b. four and for

~~c. our and hour~~

d. tail and tale

12. Rewrite this sentence by replacing each underlined word with the correct homophone:

What wee now no as Antarctica, South America, Africa, India, and Australia awl together formed won huge continent called Gondwanaland.

What we now know as Antarctica, South America, Africa, India, and Australia all together formed one huge continent called Gondwanaland

PRACTICE 3: WHAT CAN WE HEAR HERE?

Read this rhyme, and then answer the questions that follow.

I went down by the *sea*, to find out what I could *see*, With *four* fine friends *for* company, We started down a *stair*, but all stopped to *stare* At a frog and a striped *bass* that we saw sitting *there*! The frog played a trumpet; the fish strummed a *bass*, And each of them had a big smile on his face! They finished *their* song, took a *bow* and turned to go, As a turtle gave them flowers all *tied* up with a *bow*! “Now what kind of *conduct* is this?” asked I, “To *conduct* a concert where people need to pass by?” “Oh, we only play *here* after the *tide* has come in,” Said the horn-playing frog with a large froggy grin.

“Come up the *beach* now, over near that *beech* tree And you’ll *hear* some jazz that’s as cool as can be!” So we listened to their music and joined them in dance, You should really go hear them, if you have the chance!

13. The first homophone in line 3 means...

~~a.~~ look at.

b. step.

c. rip apart.

d. beach.

14. Which are NOT homophones?

a. wear, where, ware

b. by, buy, bye

~~c.~~ tide, tied, teid

d. so, sew, sow

15. The homograph *bass* that rhymes with *face* means....

a. a kind of fish.

b. a kind of beach.

c. a kind of turtle.

~~d.~~ a musical instrument.

A. Synonyms and Antonyms

KNOWING WORDS WITH the same or opposite meaning can help you make sense of unknown words.

When you read, you may come across a word you don’t know. You can often figure out its meaning by thinking of a synonym or antonym for it.

A **synonym** means the same, or almost the same, as the unknown word.

Example

I felt so *ungainly*, tripping over my own feet as we headed to the dance floor!

Can you think of a word to replace *ungainly* that would still describe someone who trips? How about *clumsy*, *awkward*, or *gawky*? They all have about the same meaning, but doesn’t it sound more embarrassing to be *ungainly* than *clumsy*? By using *ungainly*, the author tells you more about the person’s feelings.

An **antonym** means the opposite of the unknown word.

Example

He collapsed after another *arduous* day of work in the mine. Can you think of a word to describe work that probably would NOT make someone collapse? How about *easy*, *simple*, or *effortless*? They all mean the opposite of *hard* or *difficult*, which is what *arduous* means! *Also*, *or*, and *like* often signal a synonym is in the text near an unknown word. *But* or *unlike* often signal an antonym. Use the synonym or antonym to help you figure out the unknown word.

Example

Gigi thought she’d be calm once the test was over, but now she was *angst-ridden* about the results. The word *but* in the example signals an antonym. Gigi thought she’d be calm, but she’s the opposite. So *angst-ridden* must mean “anxious” or “worried.” Here are just a few words with their synonyms and antonyms.

Note how a synonym may mean the same but give a different feeling to the original word, and you may add some more ...

Word	Synonym	Antonym
afraid	petrified	valiant
ask	interrogate	retort
begin	commence	terminate
correct	accurate	erroneous
friend	cohort	antagonist
laugh	chortle	snivel
naughty	mischievous	compliant
noisy	boisterous	tranquil
repair	renovate	demolish
small	minuscule	gargantuan
true	authentic	bogus
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____
_____	_____	_____

PRACTICE 1: PEBBLE POTTAGE

Based on a European Folktale

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

- (1) One day, a *vagrant* knocked on a farmhouse door. The farmer's wife peered out at the weary *drifter*. "I can't let you in," she said, "for my husband is not at home. And besides, I have no *sustenance* to offer because my husband is bringing groceries back from town."
- (2) "Then, Madam, you can share some of my pebble potage!" the man replied, and he pulled from his pocket what looked like an ordinary stone.
- (3) "Pebble pottage?" asked the woman, suddenly interested in the ragged man.
- (4) "Oh, yes, it is delicious," he said with a smile. "If I had a pot of water and a fire, I could demonstrate how this stone can magically make the best soup you've ever tasted!"
- (5) The woman was curious, so she opened the door and the *wayfarer* came inside. Soon a pot of water was boiling away. He dropped in the stone, then tasted the watery broth. "It needs a pinch of salt, and a dash of pepper," he said. "You wouldn't have any, would you? And perhaps a tiny bit of butter?"
- (6) "No problem," said the woman, and she ran to get the requested *components*.
- (7) When she returned, he added the salt, pepper, and butter to the broth and tasted it again. "Yum. Much better!" he said. "But vegetables would add even more flavor! Are there none in your cellar or garden?"
- (8) "Oh, there must be a few," she said, eager to taste the magic soup. So she ran to the garden and returned with some potatoes, carrots, and beans.
- (9) These were added and the *vagabond* tasted the mixture again. "The magic stone has not failed me!" he whispered *surreptitiously*. "It is almost ready. All it needs is a bit of meat."
- (10) The woman found some leftover chicken in the refrigerator and added it to the pot, saying, "Magic stone, do your thing!"
- (11) Before long, a wonderful aroma filled the kitchen, *portending* that the soup was done. The woman filled a bowl for the man and one for herself. And there was enough left for her husband to have a bowlful when he returned.
- (12) "Thank you so much for letting me use your pot and fire," the stranger said as he prepared to leave. He *extracted* his stone from the bottom of the pot, washed it off, and put it back into his pocket.
- (13) "Oh, you are welcome. Do come again," said the woman.
- (14) "Indeed I will," replied the hobo. "Now, because of your kindness, I want to leave you a gift." He fished into his other pocket and brought out a tiny pebble. "Here," he said with a smile, "is your very own magic pebble. It is not yet fully matured so it can only make enough soup for one. Use it well."
- (15) Then he left and disappeared into the woods. The farmer's wife never saw him again, but she did enjoy a small cup of magic pebble pottage from time to time!

1. Which synonym was NOT used to describe the stranger?

- a. hobo b. vagrant c. wayfarer ~~d. bum~~
2. An antonym for the word *extricated* is
a. rescued. ~~b. inserted.~~ ~~c. took out.~~ d. removed.
3. Which is a synonym for *portending*?
a. suggesting b. signifying c. indicating ~~d. all of the above~~
4. Which is NOT an antonym for *surreptitiously*?
a. sneakily b. furtively ~~c. openly~~ d. secretly

PRACTICE 2: HOT SPOT

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

(1) The Panamint Indians, who were the *primary* inhabitants of California's Death Valley, called it *Tomesha*, meaning "ground afire." And it is a real hot spot. In fact, it holds the record for the highest temperature ever documented in the United States—134° F (57° C), recorded in July 1913! Death Valley also holds the record for the lowest point in the Western Hemisphere—a salty pool in Badwater, 282 feet (86 m) below sea level!

(2) Normally, Death Valley gets only about 2 inches (5 cm) of rain annually. Some plants have adapted to the dry, desert life, as have kangaroo rats, scorpions, small lizards, and rattlesnakes. They find *sustenance* and can use the vegetation for shade in the extreme heat. But about every 50 years or so, it rains more in Death Valley. That's what happened in 2005. Winter storms dumped an *excessive* amount—6 inches (15 cm)—on the valley. The result? A rare showcase of color!

(3) For decades, wildflower seeds with thick or waxy *veneers* had been germinating underground. When the heavy rains came, the additional moisture coaxed the seeds to bloom. And they did, in an array of beautiful color all over the desert floor!

(4) The plants started a chain reaction. Caterpillars and moths flocked to the area to feed on the flowers. The insects then attracted birds and small rodents, which in turn attracted snakes and foxes, *fabricating* a whole new food chain in Death Valley.

(5) Now the flowers are gone and the dry, hot weather has returned. But the blossoms dropped new seeds that will remain dormant in the ground waiting for the next really wet winter. Until then, other parts of the new food chain will have to look for nourishment elsewhere!

5. A synonym for the word *sustenance* is....
a. pollution. b. devastation. c. food. d. flooding.
6. Which is NOT an antonym for *fabricating*?
a. constructing b. destroying c. devastating d. razing
7. The author could have used the synonym *sleeping* instead of
a. array. b. vegetation. c. documented. d. dormant.
8. Which antonym pair is used in the selection?
a. *tallest* and *shortest* b. *lowest* and *highest* c. *oldest* and *newest* d. *hottest* and *coldest*
9. Which is a synonym for *veneer*?
a. roots b. veins c. stems d. coatings
10. A synonym for the word *excessive* is
a. recessive. b. disproportionate. c. declined. d. meager.

PRACTICE 3: REVOLUTIONARY RESOLUTION

A Young Colonist's Decision

Read the poem, and then answer the questions that follow.

Patriot or Loyalist, which one will I be? My *kin* came here from England, but I'm a colonist, you see. We have *resided* here all of my life; we *toil* hard every day, So why should we pay *levies* to a *monarch* far away? The people who really love this land will *wrestle* to make it free. I love this land and I shall fight . . . so a Patriot I will be! Men and women, girls and boys, speak up for democracy, So we can *resolve* what's best for us, rather than someone across the sea!

11. Which is a synonym for *kin*?

- a. teacher b. family c. farmers d. engineer

12. If *resolve* means "choose," an antonym would be

- a. decide. b. determine. c. disallow. d. establish.

13. A synonym for *levies* is....

- a. chairs. b. taxes. c. statues. d. attention.

14. An antonym for *toil* is....

- a. relax. b. hustle. c. work. d. labor.

B. Prefixes and Suffixes

In this lesson, you'll discover how word parts can help you figure out word meaning.

SOME WORDS ARE made up of parts, like base words, roots, prefixes, and suffixes.

A **base word** is a real word that can stand alone. You can make new words from it by adding other word parts.

Examples

Base word Words made by adding parts

think thinking, rethink, unthinkable, thinker agree agreeable, disagree, agreement

A **root** can't stand alone. Many roots come from Greek or Latin words.

Examples

Root Origin English example

dict Latin for *say* diction

spect Greek for *observe* inspect

A **prefix** is a group of letters added to the beginning of a base word, like the *re-* in *rethink*. A prefix changes the meaning of the base word.

Examples

Prefix Meaning Example

sub under submarine, underwater vessel

un- not unbelievable, not to be believed

A **suffix** is a group of letters added to the end of a base word. The suffix also changes the meaning of the base word.

Examples

Suffix Meaning Examples

-less without sleepless, clueless, hopeless

-ly in that way gladly, quickly, immediately

You can use word parts to help you figure out the meaning of unknown words. Look at parts of the word. Do you recognize the base word? Be aware that added parts can change the base word's part of speech. For example, a verb might become a noun or a noun might become an adjective. Put the parts together and guess the meaning. Try out your idea in the sentence. If it makes sense, you're most likely right!

Example

I know he was upset, but his actions were *indefensible*!

Prefix Base Suffix

in- defends -ible

not- justif(justify) -able

Put the parts together: not *justifiable*. Try it in the sentence: I know he was upset, but his actions were not *justifiable*! Does it make sense? Yes!

PRACTICE 1: THE BIRD WOMAN

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

(1) In 1804, explorers Meriwether Lewis and William Clark set out on an expedition to map thousands of miles, from the Dakotas to the Pacific Ocean. They knew they needed horses to cross the mountains, and that the Shoshone in the territory had horses. But Lewis and Clark didn't speak the Shoshone language, so how would they be able to trade with the Shoshone for fresh horses? Happily, the explorers found a solution. They would take along Sacagawea, a Shoshone whose name means "Bird Woman," to speak for them.

(2) On the long journey, Sacagawea did more than just intervene with the Shoshone for the explorers. She also helped the group survive. She could predict which plants were safe to eat and prepared nutritious meals. She used natural materials to make clothing for them to wear and medicines to cure their ills. And she reassured other Indian tribes along the way that the explorers were on a peaceful mission and meant them no harm. Just the sight of a young woman, who also brought along her young child, convinced tribes that this was no war party.

(3) Sacagawea also showed her bravery. When a sudden gust of strong wind almost capsized the boat in which she was riding, Sacagawea remained calm. She carefully recovered many important papers, medicine, and other vital supplies that would otherwise have been lost. Sacagawea's calmness under pressure and her hard work, earned high praise from Lewis and Clark. They honored her by naming part of a Montana river "Bird Woman's River." Later, statues of Sacagawea and books about her kept her memory alive. And in 2000, the U.S. Mint even honored Sacagawea by putting her image on a gold dollar coin!

1. The root *dict* means "say" and the prefix *pre-* means "before," so *predict* means

- | | |
|-----------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| a. say afterwards, or contradict. | b. tell again, or repeat. |
| c. refuse to say, deny. | d. say in advance, or foretell. |

2. What does *happily* mean?

- | | | | |
|----------------|-------------------|-------------------|-----------------------|
| a. happy again | b. happy together | c. in a happy way | d. not in a good mood |
|----------------|-------------------|-------------------|-----------------------|

3. The *peace* in *peaceful* is....

- | | | | |
|-----------------|-----------------|--------------|--------------|
| a. a root word. | b. a base word. | c. a prefix. | d. a suffix. |
|-----------------|-----------------|--------------|--------------|

4. The prefix *re-* means "again," so the word *reassured* means

- | | | | |
|----------------------|------------------|-----------------------|---------------------|
| a. guaranteed again. | b. forgot again. | c. gave a gift again. | d. all of the above |
|----------------------|------------------|-----------------------|---------------------|

5. Which is the meaning of *calmness*?

- | | |
|----------------------------|---------------------------|
| a. to be stressed again | b. having an advantage |
| c. the state of being calm | d. have a reason to worry |

6. How would knowing the root *ven* means "come, go" and the prefix *inter* means "between" help you figure out the meaning of *intervene* as used in the selection?

PRACTICE 2: PAWS FOR ALARM

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

- (1) It was late when Dad pulled the van up to the old ski cabin. I grabbed a suitcase and headed toward the front door. My cat Sage jumped out to follow me, daintily scampering to keep the cold, wet snow away from her paws. Sage had a touch of arthritis and didn't find winter weather enjoyable!
- (2) A sizeable carpet of snow covered the porch, so I dragged my feet to make a path for us. Dad unlocked the door and Sage scurried inside, looking for a dry place to nap. Dad built a fire in the old fireplace, and soon the room was warm and cozy.
- (3) I went down the hall to my room, with Sage behind me. She jumped up on my bed and curled up in a small furry ball. "I'll be joining you soon," I said.
- (4) Just then, Dad popped his head into the room. "Let's call it a day," he said with a yawn. "See you in the morning for an early ski?"
- (5) I nodded in agreement, and Dad went to his room and shut the door. As I slipped under the covers, I looked out the window at the snow falling ever faster. "The ski runs will be awesome tomorrow!" I mumbled sleepily.
- (6) I don't know how long I was asleep before Sage's whiskers rubbed against my face. "Stop," I pleaded gently, but she purred loudly and pushed me with her head. "Stop!" I hissed, not even opening my eyes. She let out a loud MEOW! This was so unlike her. She'd slept beside me since she was a kitten, and she'd never bothered me before! Just as I was about to drift back into a peaceful sleep, she leaped on me with all four paws . . . HARD! Then she zipped across the room and slammed up against the window glass! THUMP!
- (7) I opened my eyes, but everything was foggy . . . and my head hurt. Then I coughed . . . smoke . . . there was smoke seeping in under the door! I didn't open the door, I felt it like firefighters say you should. The wood was hot . . . that meant there was fire on the other side! We had to get out!
- (8) Sage batted her paws against the window glass. "Okay, I get it," I cried as I ran to open the window, but it was stuck! I continued to push, and at last, it opened. Cold, fresh air filled my lungs as we climbed out the window. I picked up Sage and ran to the window of Dad's room. I banged on the glass, but he didn't answer. So I threw a rock to break the glass, and screamed his name. Finally, he stumbled to the window and scrambled out.
- (9) The firefighters who put out the blaze said sparks from the fireplace had set the rug on fire. "We'll put in smoke alarms today," Dad said. "I only wish we'd had them last night!"
- (10) "From what I hear, you had a live smoke alarm," one firefighter said, stroking Sage's soft fur. "She's quite a hero!" Sage just purred and closed her eyes, anxious to get that nap at last!

7. If the root *artho* means "joint" and the suffix *-itis* means "inflammation," Sage most likely
- a. has difficulty hearing.
 - b. has aches and pains in her legs.
 - c. has difficulty seeing.
 - d. has a problem eating cat food.
8. The suffix *-able* means "capable of being" and changes the base word *size*
- a. to a pronoun.
 - b. to a verb.
 - c. to an adjective.
 - d. to a plural noun.
9. The prefix *un-* changes the base word *like* to mean...
- a. the same.
 - b. not understood.
 - c. not known.
 - d. not similar.
10. If the prefix *ad-* means "to" and the Latin word *jacere* means "lie near," the word *adjacent* means
- a. far-off.
 - b. adjoining.
 - c. distant.
 - d. none of the above

PRACTICE 3: FURRY FORECASTER

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

- (1) February 2 is Groundhog Day. In many places, people believe that on that day, the groundhog will come out of its subterranean burrow and predict the weather. Legends say that if it's sunny that

day, the groundhog will see its shadow, be frightened, go back into its burrow, and sleep some more. This is supposed to indicate that spring is still six weeks away.

(2) The legends add that if it's cloudy, the groundhog won't see a shadow, so it will remain above ground. This is supposed to be a sign that spring will soon arrive! So every February, reporters rush to witness a groundhog pop up from underground. The journalists write about what happens and TV shows air video of the action as the groundhog exits its winter home.

(3) Are the legends believable? Well, scientists have recorded that clear February days are often followed by much colder ones. And it's been noted that cloudy days in February are usually warm. Historical weather documents reveal that sometimes the groundhog is right, but other times it is mistaken. If you really want to know what the weather will be, check your local TV meteorologist!

11. Since *terra* means "Earth," *subterranean* means

- a. above ground. b. below ground. c. at ground level. d. over the ground.

12. If the suffix *-ist* means "one who does," *journalist* means

- a. a person who sings. b. a person who cooks.
c. a person who writes. d. a person who builds.

13. Which is the meaning of *believable* as used in the article?

- a. able to organize b. not truthful c. suspected d. worthy of belief

C. Terminology and Jargon

In this lesson, you'll discover that the words you use may differ, depending on who you're talking to.

PEOPLE WHO WORK together or do things as a group may have their own language of special terms, or jargon, that makes it easy for them to communicate with one another. For example, if you use the Internet, you know what IM (instant message), website, and sayings like LOL (laugh out loud) mean. But someone who's never used a computer might be very confused! There are special terms and jargon that relate to science, art, music, cooking, politics, and just about any topic. On the following page are some examples.

Word Topic Meaning

aperture photography camera lens opening apogee space an orbiting object's highest point from Earth
blog Internet short for Weblog, a personal journal to share online braise cooking prepare slowly with
little moisture in a closed pot caucus politics a meeting of only members in a political party colonnade
architecture row of columns currency banking coins and paper money ligaments medicine fibers that
connect bones subtrahend math number that is to be subtracted wings theater areas off both sides of
the main stage.

Read this sample of jargon and see if you can guess what group of people might use the language.

Squeeze one, two chicks on a raft—wreck 'em, shingle with a shimmy and a shake, and city juice—
86 the hail. If you guessed people who work in a restaurant, especially a diner, you're right. It's how
some waiters give an order for one orange juice, two eggs on toast—scrambled, buttered toast with
jam, and water—hold the ice! Now that's really a special vocabulary.

PRACTICE 1: QUIET ON THE SET!

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

(1) Last summer I visited my uncle Ron. The public relations firm he works for was handling the ads for an upcoming movie, and he took me to watch a shoot! "Let's go meet the a.d.," Ron said when we got to the studio.

(2) "You *meet* an ad?" I asked, a little confused.

(3) "Oh, sorry, that's the assistant director," he laughed. "You get so used to the jargon on the set that you figure everyone else knows it."

- (4) The a.d., whose name was Mim, pointed out that “The d.p. is using a dolly to track some actors running a scene.” I guess I looked confused because she smiled, “He’s the director of photography, or cinematographer . . . around here we just call him the d.p. He runs the camera; it’s his job to get the best shot every time!”
- (5) “And the camera’s on a dolly,” I said knowingly, “I saw a platform on wheels like that at my dad’s store. It’s on tracks, like a train. Is it always there?”
- (6) “No, we move them after the d.p. gets the final shot,” she replied.
- (7) Just then, someone called, “Where’s the gaffer? We need a blue gel. And can someone just close the barn door on that one?” he called, pointing up.
- (8) “They need an electrician,” Uncle Ron whispered. “They want a blue filter over the light . . . blue light is softer, not so harsh.”
- (9) “Got it,” I replied. “But what’s a barn door?”
- (10) Mim pointed up at the huge lights. “See the flaps on the front of the light? They can be opened or closed to give more or less light. We call them barn doors.”
- (11) I didn’t say it, but I thought, “That’s silly; why not just call them flaps?”
- (12) Later, I saw two actors filming a sword fight in front of a green wall.
- “Without scenery, how will anyone know if they’re in a castle or on a cliff? I asked.
- (13) “That’s where c.g.i. comes in,” explained Mim. “The action is filmed in front of a blue or green screen, then a computer-generated image is dropped in for the background. It’ll make them look like they’re dueling atop the Statue of Liberty or in a hall at Buckingham Palace, whatever the filmmakers want.”
- (14) “So if I see an actor riding a camel in a desert, is he really doing it?” I asked.
- (15) “Sometimes,” Mim replied. “Some films are shot on location at different spots around the world. But it costs less to use blue-screen and c.g.i., so it’s up to the filmmakers and their budget. They may want *movie magic*.”
- (16) “We need background people for the next scene,” someone called to Mim.
- (17) She nodded. “Time for me to make sure the people you may know as *extras* are in place,” she confided. “They’re the ones who give the scene a sense of reality—folks walking down a street or shopping in a mall as the stars do their thing.”
- (18) After lunch, we watched more filming. “Quiet on the set!” someone called. “Rolling! Action!”
- (19) The background people began to move, then into the scene rode the hero, the star of the movie, on a real motorcycle! No green screen needed!

1. In which would you most likely use jargon like *cinematographer*?

a. medicine	b. sports	c. construction	d. film production
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2. What is the meaning of *a.d.* as used in the selection?

a. after delivery	b. artistic director	c. assistant director	d. actors’ directory
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3. A gaffer is

a. in charge of serving lunch on a movie set.	c. the star of a movie
b. a worker for an advertising agency.	d. an electrician.
4. A c.g.i. is dropped in as background for action that’s shot in front of

a. a live audience.	b. a blue or green screen.	c. Buckingham Palace.	d. a white screen.
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PRACTICE 2: MONEY MATTERS

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

- (1) Today we use two basic kinds of currency, or money: metal coins and paper bills. But once people bartered, or traded, for things they needed or wanted. In ancient Africa, salt was really valuable because people in many places didn’t have it, and they needed it to flavor and preserve their food. So people would trade a bag of gold for a bag of salt!
- (2) Then, about 3,500 years ago, people started using seashells as money. The North American Indians used wampum, beads made of clamshells. In about 1,000 B.C., the Chinese minted the first metal coins. They had holes in the centers so they could be carried on a string, kind of like a key ring. Later, the Chinese invented paper money.
- (3) Before long, people around the world used coins and paper money to buy goods. Most people kept their money at home, tucked under a mattress or a floorboard, or stuffed in a jar. But often the money was stolen or lost in a flood or fire. And sometimes people just forgot where they had hidden it!

That's why banks were built. The special buildings were equipped with vaults—rooms where everyone's money was locked up and guarded. People who put their money in a bank felt that the cash was safe.

(4) The first bank in the United States opened in 1791. Today there are thousands. To open an account at a bank, a person must be at least 18 years old. That's because only adults can legally sign papers needed to open the account. An account holder can deposit, or put in, more money from time to time. It's added to the balance, or total already in the account. He or she can also withdraw, or take out, money that's then subtracted from the balance.

(5) People can deposit or withdraw money at the bank or at an ATM (Automatic Teller Machine). Each account holder is given a plastic card that electronically holds information about the account. The machine scans the card, then allows the person to deposit or withdraw money, or check the current balance.

5. Jargon like *currency*, *deposit*, and *ATM* are used in the field of

- a. baking. b. science c. banking. d. auto racing.

6. What is the meaning of *mint* as used in the selection?

- a. a flavored candy b. flawless c. green, leafy plant d. produced

7. What is the meaning of *vault* as used in the selection?

- a. to leap over b. a burial chamber c. a room for the safekeeping of valuables d. to cover

8. Wampum was currency made from

- a. clamshells. b. turkey feathers. c. salt. d. paper.

9. To open a bank account, a person must be

- a. an American citizen. b. at least 18 years old. c. at least 21 years old. d. a high school graduate.

10. The meaning of *balance* as used in the selection is

- a. steadiness. b. set of scales. c. total. d. compare.

PRACTICE 3: MANAGE MINERALS

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

(1) Rocks are made of minerals. Those are substances that can't be classified as "animals" or "vegetables." There are many different minerals. Each can be identified by its properties, or characteristics. To identify a mineral, scientists test its streak, hardness, luster, color, and cleavage.

(2) To test the streak, the mineral is rubbed on a marble slab to see if it leaves a mark, and if so, what color mark. To test hardness, the mineral is scratched on glass to see if it scratches the glass, and if so, how much. Scientists can see the mineral's luster, or shininess, to know if it's metallic or nonmetallic. The mineral's color is also obvious to the eye. Finally, the mineral is checked for cleavage—breaks, or fractures, along weak points.

(3) An accurate identification of a mineral can't be done by checking just one property. Many minerals have similar properties, such as the same hardness or color. Always test all the properties before stating for sure which mineral it is.

11. In which topic would you most likely find words like *minerals* and *metallic*?

- a. music b. cooking c. science d. ballet

12. Every substance is classified as either an animal, a vegetable, or a

- a. mineral. b. human. c. solid. d. liquid.

13. What is the meaning of *streak* as used in the article?

- a. run fast b. a mark of color c. to distort d. to stretch

D. Context Clues

In this lesson, you'll discover that authors give clues in the text to help you understand what you read. You just have to be a word detective and find them! **SOMETIMES AUTHORS NEED** or want to use words they know will be unknown by their readers. So authors slip in other words or phrases to help readers figure out the unknown ones. Authors may define the word, give examples of similar things, or restate the idea to make it clearer. And authors may put the clues in the text itself or in nearby pictures. Readers use these context clues to make good guesses about what unknown words mean.

Definition

He played the *harpsichord*, a piano-like musical instrument.

Examples

The largest group is *arthropods*, like spiders, insects, and lobsters.

Restate to clarify

She ran to the *escarpment*. Could she climb down the steep hill in time to escape?

Sometimes an author just wants readers to understand the context of a word, not necessarily the exact meaning.

*If I could tell you what it meant,
there would be no point in dancing it.*

In this lesson, you'll discover that authors give clues in the text to help you understand what you read. You just have to be a word detective and find them! Dan was surprised that he hadn't won the election. "That's *implausible*!" he whined.

Now you may not know exactly what *implausible* means, but you can get the idea that it's not good because Dan whines, so he's not *happily* surprised! (**Implausible** means *unbelievable*.)

Look for all kinds of context clues to help you as you read.

PRACTICE 1: PLANNING AHEAD

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

(1) It was late when Marco finally got to the store. He'd been planning this surprise party for weeks, but somehow time was running out! "I can handle it all by myself," he'd told his mom when he first suggested a surprise party for his cousin's birthday. "I mean, how hard it is to throw a party?"

(2) "It can be very time-consuming. There's a lot to do," replied his mom. But Marco reiterated, "I can handle it all myself!"

(3) Marco did all the mundane, tedious things first, like making a list of who to invite, buying the invitations, and addressing and mailing them out. He found it somewhat irritating when people called to RSVP right in the middle of his favorite TV show, but he thanked them and checked their names on the list so he'd know who would and wouldn't be attending the party.

(4) Then he planned the menu. He knew Paco loved Crema Catalana—a cold custard with a crispy, crunchy, caramel coating. Marco thought his mom made the best, so he asked her to make it for the party. Of course, he planned to have a giant birthday cake with candles for Paco to blow out for luck. Marco also picked other good things to serve.

(5) The day of the party, Marco blew up balloons and made colorful garlands. He draped the paper-chain ribbons across the curtains and attached the balloons to the wall with double-stick tape. Everything looked quite festive. He called his Uncle Santiago to make sure he'd bring Paco at the right time, supposedly just to drop in for a minute on the way to dinner. Then Marco checked on the food supplies. The snacks were ready. The Crema Catalana was in the refrigerator keeping cold, awaiting that final, lastminute caramel topping. And the cake was ready, awaiting the candles on top. . . "Oh, no!" Marco cried. "I forgot to pick up candles! Mom, do we have any birthday candles?"

(6) "Sorry, honey," she replied. "I wish you'd told me. . . I could have picked some up on the way home. You'll have to run to the store to get some."

(7) And that's how Marco ended up at the store just before closing, when there was just one checkout open, and a very slow clerk. The lady in front of Marco kept asking, "Is it always this slow?" After the fifth time, Marco replied, somewhat politely, "Yes, ma'am, except on Thursdays. Why don't you come back then?"

(8) The lady turned in a huff and galumphed out of the store, leaving one less person in front of Marco.

(9) Finally, Marco got to the counter. “I just have these birthday candles, Ma’am, and I can’t be late for the party,” he said hurriedly as he put some money on the counter. “Just keep the change!”

(10) He ran home as fast as he could, arriving just in time to hear everyone inside yell “Surprise!” as Paco and Uncle Santiago walked in the door ahead of him!

1. Which is most likely the meaning of *reiterate*?

- a. refused b. said for the first time c. said again d. sat down

2. Which is NOT a meaning of *mundane*?

- a. boring b. ordinary c. dull d. unusual

3. What kind of context clue does the author use for Crema Catalana?

- a. an example of a similar dessert b. a definition c. a synonym d. none of the above

4. What kind of context clue does the author use for *garlands*?

- a. a definition b. an antonym c. a restatement to clarify d. examples of other hanging objects

5. From the context, which is most likely the meaning of *galumphed*?

- a. tip-toed b. ran c. stomped d. skipped

PRACTICE 2: IN SIGHT

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

(1) What causes myopia? You probably know that we see because light bounces off objects and into our eyes. In a normal eye, the light rays go through the lens and focus on the retina, the sensory membrane or sheet that lines the eye, to create images. In myopic eyes, the light focuses in front of the retina instead of directly on it. So nearsighted people can usually see really well up close, but they squint to try to see things far away.

(2) Often, nearsightedness is suspected if a kid has trouble seeing the chalkboard or whiteboard in school. Then a vision test is set up to diagnose perception. In other words, a doctor checks how well the person can read various sized letters at various distances.

(3) Early diagnosis is important because nearsightedness can be ameliorated with corrective visual devices, like glasses and contact lenses. These devices can’t “cure” myopia, but they help a nearsighted person see distant objects more clearly. The lens of the glasses or contacts refocuses the light before it reaches the eye so it hits the retina where it should.

(4) Doctors can also do surgery to help some people who have myopia. Adults with myopia, whose glasses or contact prescription hasn’t changed for at least a year, may be able to have a laser procedure that can clear up their problem.

(5) Nearsightedness affects men and women equally. People with a family history of myopia are more likely to develop it. And there’s no way to prevent it. At one time people actually believed that reading too much or watching too much TV caused nearsightedness. Those activities can make your eyes tired, but they can’t cause myopia.

6. What kind of context clue does the author use for *myopia*?

- a. a restatement to clarify b. a definition c. a homonym d. examples of other eye problems

7. What is the retina?

- a. a ray of light b. a lens c. a membrane, or lining d. a light shaft

8. What is the meaning of *diagnose*?

- a. detect b. identify c. analyze d. all of the above

9. Which is most likely the meaning of *ameliorated*?

- a. worsened b. improved c. continued d. renewed

10. For which does the author give two or more examples as context clues?

- a. kinds of membranes in the body b. lenses in cameras
c. corrective visual devices d. types of eye conditions

11. If you didn’t know the meaning of *surgery*, which nearby word would be a clue?

- a. doctors b. myopia c. glasses d. problem

PRACTICE 2: VAST VESSELS

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

(1) Galleons were large ships used by Europeans from the sixteenth to eighteenth centuries. Equipped with three or four masts and two or more decks, these gallant ships helped countries like Spain and England establish their naval power.

(2) A galleon's sides were 3–4 feet (.9–1.2 m) thick, strong enough to hold the heavy foremast and mainmast, both equipped with huge square sails. The foremast was, as the word *fore* suggests, the one closest to the front, or bow, of the ship. One or two smaller masts were toward the ship's stern, or rear. They had lateens—three-cornered sails. Openings on the ship's sides held heavy cannons.

(3) After the discovery of the Americas, the Spanish used fleets of galleons to ship home chattel from the Americas, like gold, silver, and precious gems. But many ships never made it back. Hard to maneuver, they often couldn't evade lighter pirate ships. And many galleons sank during violent hurricanes. Today, treasure-hunting divers still find the wreckage of the majestic ships and their caches of riches today.

12. A foremast is

- a. the mast closest to the stern.
- b. the mast closest to the bow.
- c. the mast in the middle.
- d. the tallest mast.

13. Which is most likely the meaning of *chattel*?

- a. lands
- b. information
- c. advice
- d. Possessions

14. From the context of the selection, *maneuver* most likely means

- a. study or read.
- b. paint and restore.
- c. steer or guide.
- d. submerge and sink.

E. Denotation and Connotation

In this lesson, you'll find that a word may suggest something quite different from what it really means.

EVERY WORD HAS a denotation—its definition as found in a dictionary. But many words also have a connotation—the feelings or images they bring to mind.

Example

snake

Denotation: scaly, legless reptile

Connotation: danger, evil, disloyal person

Even words that mean the same may have different connotations. Think about the synonyms *scary* and *terrifying*. They have similar meanings, but produce different feelings. There's a big difference between the scary sound of the howling wind and a terrifying experience like falling off a cliff! Authors choose words to influence how readers feel. The words may suggest positive or negative connotations. In this lesson, you'll find that a word may suggest something quite different from what it really means.

Example

I saw many *homeless people* on the streets of the city. (*positive*)

I saw many *bums* on the streets of the city. (*negative*)

Here are a few more positive and negative connotations of words.

Word Use Positive Negative

Grandpa is *thrifty*. spends money wisely cheap

She's very *strong-willed*. determined stubborn

He has good *self-esteem*. proud of work well done conceited

She was tall and *slender*. slim anorexic

He's an *eager* leader. enthusiastic impatient

As you read, look for both positive and negative connotations. Ask yourself why the author wants you to get that connotation.

PRACTICE 1: “IT’S FOR YOU!”

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

(1) You can’t go anywhere today without running into someone using a cell phone. People are either talking on them or texting. Okay, so we know the handheld devices are helpful tools, but shouldn’t there be some rules about their use in society? Just because someone has a cell phone, does that make it okay to talk rowdily on it in public? Does everyone in the vicinity have to be bombarded with one-sided conversations, even if they don’t want to? Not everyone agrees.

(2) Some people, usually those who use their cells a lot, say it’s totally okay to use them anywhere, anytime. They may allege, “America’s a free country and it’s my right to talk in public! Other people talk to each other all the time while they walk down the street or eat in a restaurant. What’s the difference if I talk to someone face-to-face or on a cell? If other people don’t like hearing my phone conversations, they don’t have to listen! I think *they* should move away from me so they don’t hear what I’m saying! After all, it’s very rude to eavesdrop! Besides, cells phones are essential in today’s world. You see stories on TV all the time about people trapped in elevators, or under rubble from earthquakes or hurricanes, who used their cells to get help that saved their lives. And cells help kids keep in touch with their families . . . so the kids and their parents feel safer!”

(3) Other people see things differently and say things like, “Public places are for everyone. It’s true that this is a free country, so why should I be forced to listen to loud talking and laughing, especially when it’s usually about stuff that’s really lame or should be private anyway? Trust me, no one wants to hear about the fight you had with your friend, the movie you saw, or what you’re wearing to the school dance! People should be able to hang out at the mall or ride a bus without hearing brainless conversations. Last week I was almost knocked down by someone skating at the ice rink and talking on the phone at the same time! If it’s important enough for you to call someone, take the time to do it right. A phone conversation is private, so keep yours to yourself! Talking on a cell in public is not only badmannered, it adds to noise pollution!”

(4) Is there a happy medium between using a cell “wherever and whenever” and outlawing its use altogether? Sure, it’s called common sense. Be respectful of other people’s rights. Don’t talk so loudly on the phone. . . . the person on the other end can hear just fine without your shouting . . . and adjust the ring tones so you don’t hog the air that’s for all to share.

1. Which word could the author have used instead of *rowdily* that means the same but has a less negative connotation?

- a. softly b. loudly c. happily d. quietly

2. Which word in the following sentence gives a negative connotation? They may allege, “America’s a free country and it’s my right to talk in public!”

- a. free b. right c. allege d. public

3. Which word in the second paragraph is a positive connotation for *important*?

- a. essential b. difference c. conversation d. eavesdrop

4. What is the denotation of the word *hog*? What is its connotation in the last paragraph? Why do you think the author used that word?

PRACTICE 2: ONLY WOMAN MEDAL OF HONOR WINNER

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

(1) As a child, they say Mary Walker was a bit of a brat. She always wanted to do things differently. When she grew up, she continued to do so, becoming the first woman military doctor, a prisoner of war, a spy, and the only woman to win the Medal of Honor, America’s highest military award.

(2) Born in 1832, Walker graduated from medical school at the age of 21. She was the only female in her class and only the second U.S. woman to graduate from a medical school. When the Civil War broke out, she went to Washington, D.C. to become an Army surgeon. The Army gave her a tough time, so she volunteered as a nurse and went off to treat wounded soldiers.

(3) The Army finally conceded and appointed her as an assistant surgeon in 1863, making her the first female doctor in the U.S. Army. The foxy Walker esigned a military uniform for herself—a knee-length skirt over trousers and a man’s uniform jacket. To those unhappy with her garb, she clarified that the hoop skirts women normally wore were too cumbersome and dangerous when she was working in field hospitals and on battlefields.

(4) As a dedicated doctor, Walker treated those in need, no matter what their politics. So she often crossed Confederate lines to treat civilians. It’s generally accepted that while in enemy territory, she was also working as a spy for the North. On one of these trips, she was captured by Confederate troops and held in a Southern prison until both sides exchanged captives.

(5) The Army nominated Walker for the Medal of Honor and she was awarded it in 1866. Her citation praises her wartime service but doesn’t specifically mention valor in combat. That turned out to be an important oversight.

(6) In 1916, the government began reviewing Medal of Honor awards. Over the years, the medal had been copied and sold, and many people wore medals illegally. Congress revised the standard for awarding a Medal of Honor to mandate it only be given for actual combat with an enemy.

(7) Mary Walker and hundreds of past Medal of Honor recipients were stripped of their medals. The government demanded Walker and the others return theirs. She refused and wore hers until her death at age 87 in 1919.

(8) In the late 1960s, Mary’s great-grandniece launched a campaign to restore the medal her great-aunt had earned. Congress studied the case, and in 1977, President Jimmy Carter reinstated Mary Walker’s Medal of Honor.

5. A denotation of *foxy* is “like a fox” and the connotation is

- a. dull. b. clever. c. bashful. d. frightened.

6. Which word gives a negative connotation to doing things differently?

- a. continued b. graduated c. brat d. child

7. Which is probably the most positive connotation of *conceded*?

- a. okayed b. contracted c. denied d. tolerated

8. Which connotation is most negative?

- a. prisoner b. detainee c. hostage d. inmate

9. “. . . stripped of their medals” gives a more negative connotation to . . .

- a. exchanging prisoners of war. c. requesting a commission as an army surgeon.
b. working in a field hospital d. taking away an award.

10. Which word that means the same as *demand* is more positive?

- a. commanded b. asked c. decreed d. required

PRACTICE 3: WHY THE GIRAFFE’S NECK IS LONG

Read the selection, and then answer the questions that follow.

(1) Once giraffes had short necks, like horses. The giraffes ate grass, bushes, and leaves near the bottoms of trees. But the greedy animals ate and ate until all the plants were gone, except for the leaves at the very tops of the tallest trees. To get them, the giraffes stood on one another’s heads! It was quite uncomfortable, to say the least, but the leaves were tender and juicy.

(2) One day, Gayle Giraffe was perched on top, nibbling away at the leaves. Suddenly, the giraffes under her moved away, leaving her head stuck between two branches! There she dangled, far above the ground. The clever giraffe didn’t panic; she took a deep breath and stretched her body agonizingly until her hoofs felt the soft earth. Then, she pulled her neck free.

(3) “Look!” said another giraffe, who had witnessed the struggle. “Gayle’s neck has stretched! Now she can reach the leaves without climbing!”

(4) So one by one, the others stuck their heads into the branches and stretched their necks. A few giraffes were chicken and didn't want to do it, but they finally did. And now, all giraffes can eat the juiciest leaves in the treetops any time!

11. Which word could the author have used instead of *greedy* that means the same thing but does NOT have a negative connotation?

- a. miserly** **b. gluttonous** **c. selfish** **d. hungry**

12. A denotation of *chicken* is “a barnyard fowl” and the connotation is

- a.** “a brave person.” **b.** “a squawking person.” **c.** “a coward.” **d.** “a clown.”

13. Which of these words from the story has a positive connotation?

- a.** agonizingly **b.** clever **c.** dangled **d.** panic

►► **NOTE:**

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal blue ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.